

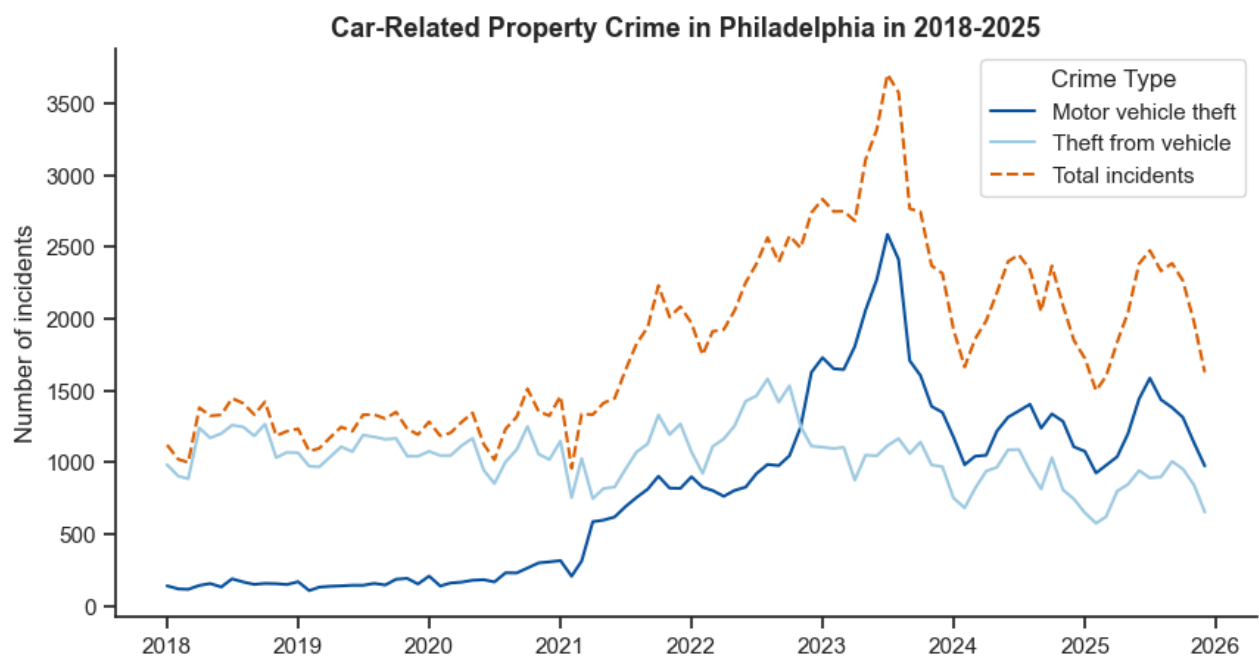
How Safe Is It to Park in Philly?

An Analysis of Motor Vehicle Theft and Theft from Vehicle in Philadelphia, 2018–2025

By Polina Adamovich

Being a car owner in Philadelphia – especially in the denser parts of the city – is a constant headache. You have to dodge basketball-size potholes, perform acrobatics to fit into tiny parking spots, and accept that hit-and-runs are practically a local tradition. You also have to stay alert for thieves. In South Philly, where I live, car alarms at midnight are basically the urban version of crickets on a farm.

I decided to look at the crime incident data from the Philadelphia Police Department to see how safe our cars really are on city streets. I focused on two car-related property crimes: **motor vehicle theft** and **theft from vehicle**. Violent offenses such as carjackings are categorized separately and are not included. The analysis covers 2018–2025, a period that corresponds closely with the tenure of incumbent Philadelphia District Attorney Larry Krasner. This makes the findings relevant to residents evaluating public safety trends during that period.



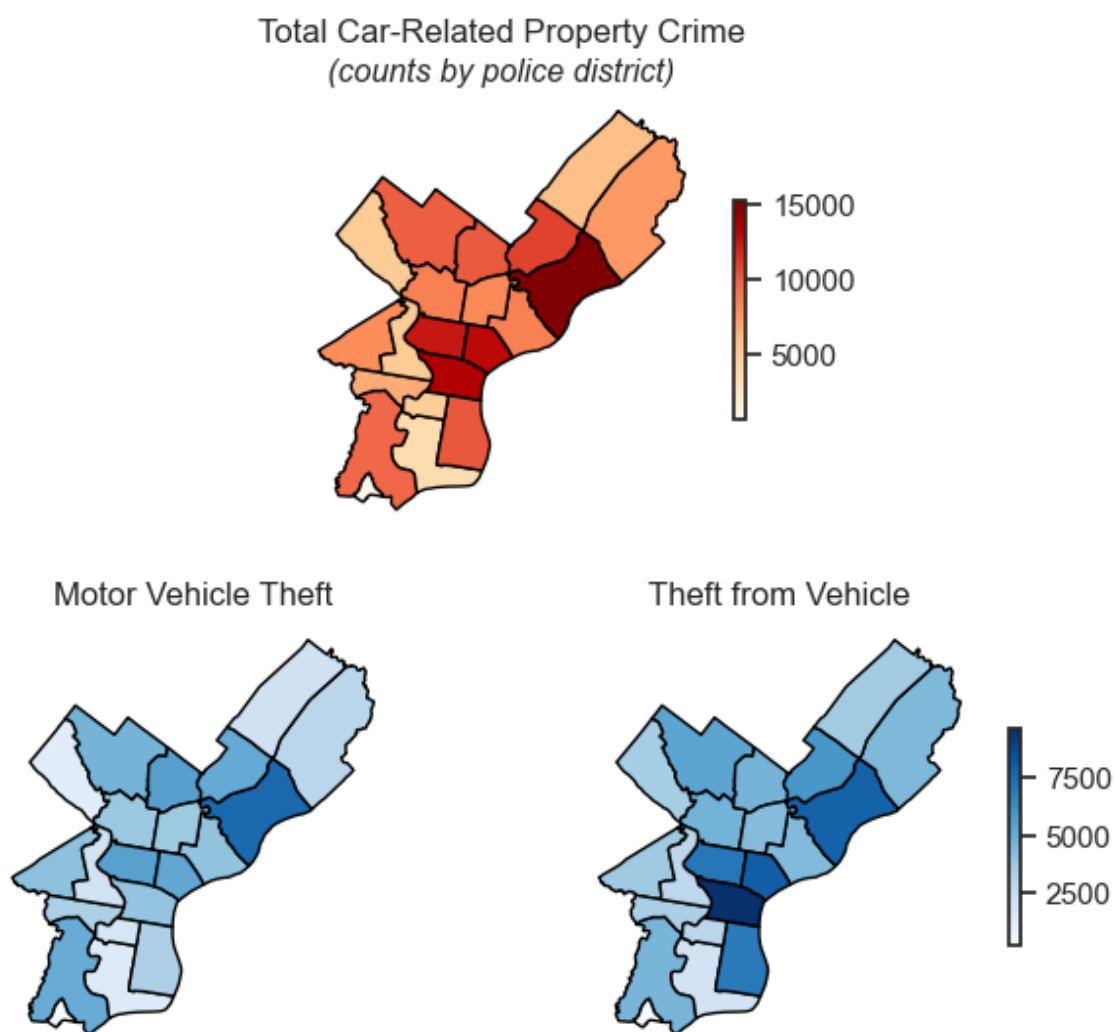
The line chart shows that from 2018 through 2021, car-related property crime was relatively stable. Most incidents involved theft from vehicles rather than theft of vehicles themselves.

That changed sharply in 2021, when motor vehicle theft began rising fast. By late 2022, vehicle thefts had surpassed thefts from vehicles and continued climbing until peaking in mid-2023. At the peak, monthly car theft totals were roughly 12 times higher than at the start of the study period. This aligns with the nationwide “Kia Challenge,” a viral [social media trend](#) that exposed how some 2011–2021 Hyundai and Kia models could be stolen with basic tools, helping fuel a surge in car thefts by teens across the U.S. between 2021 and 2023.

Since mid-2023, vehicle theft has gradually decreased, matching a national decline driven by police attention, manufacturer software updates, and the social media trend fading out. Even so, monthly theft totals in Philly remain well above pre-2021 levels.

By the end of 2025, total car-related property crime was about one-third higher than in early 2018 (roughly 1,200 monthly incidents versus 1,600). The mix of crime also changed: theft from vehicles stayed fairly flat, while vehicle theft became the dominant problem.

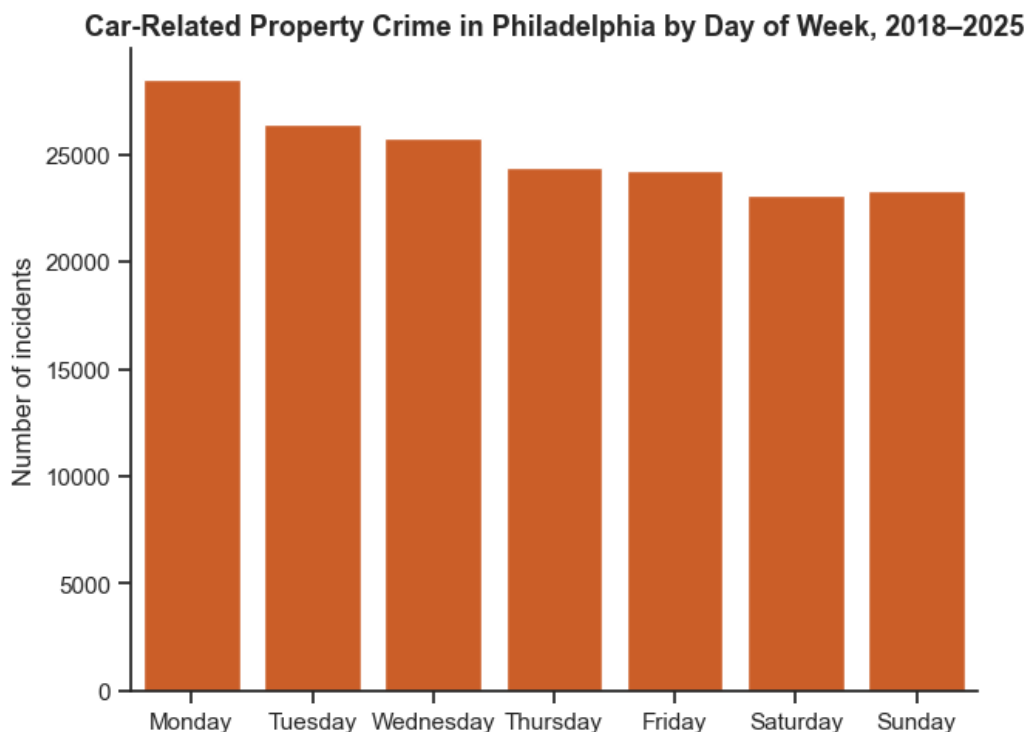
Where Car-Related Property Crime Happens in Philadelphia (2018–2025)



The maps show that many incidents are concentrated in **Northeast Philadelphia**, with additional hotspots in Center City and Old City. Breaking down incidents by type suggests that Center City and Old City are driven more by theft from vehicles, while Northeast Philadelphia experiences both categories heavily. South Philly also shows elevated theft-from-vehicle activity – which helps explain why so many neighbors invest in car alarms.

Finally, I looked at day-of-week patterns. The bar chart shows only modest variation, with a slight decline from Monday through Saturday. In short: there is **no magic “safe day”** to

park carelessly. One caveat is that the dataset records when police were dispatched, not necessarily when the crime occurred. A Sunday-night theft discovered Monday morning would likely appear as Monday.



To sum up: parking in Philadelphia has become riskier since 2018, mainly because of the sharp rise in vehicle theft after 2021. Conditions improved after the 2023 peak, but incident levels remain elevated.

Residents and visitors should stay alert across the city. Think twice before parking in Northeast Philadelphia and definitely do not leave valuables visible in Center City, Old City, or South Philly.

These patterns cannot be pinned on any single elected official or policy, but they do offer useful context for judging public safety performance during this period. Philadelphians should expect results, demand accountability, and keep their car doors locked.

Technical Note: The dataset for this project was created by combining relevant records from eight annual CSV files published by the Philadelphia Police Department and available through [OpenDataPhilly](#), covering each year in the 2018–2025 study period. The resulting dataset contained no missing values in the variables used for analysis. For the maps, crime data was merged with a [GeoJSON file](#) containing Philadelphia Police District boundaries. Data cleaning, aggregation, and visualization were completed in Jupyter Notebook using the following Python libraries: Pandas, Matplotlib, Seaborn, and GeoPandas.